

Expressivism: Writing as Self-Discovery and the Cultivation of Voice

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1 Introduction

Expressivism—sometimes called expressionism or expressivist rhetoric—is a theory of writing and composition pedagogy that places the individual writer at the center of the composing process. Rather than treating writing as the mechanical transcription of preformed ideas into correct prose, expressivists argue that writing is itself a mode of thinking, a means of self-discovery, and a vehicle for cultivating an authentic personal “voice.” Emerging in the late 1960s and gaining institutional traction throughout the 1970s, expressivism represented a decisive break from the dominant Current-Traditional Rhetoric that had governed American writing instruction since the late nineteenth century. This report examines the historical context from which expressivism arose, its core theoretical commitments, the major figures who shaped it, its characteristic pedagogical methods, and the sustained criticisms it has provoked. It concludes by assessing expressivism’s enduring legacy in contemporary writing instruction.

2 Historical Context

2.1 The Current-Traditional Paradigm

To understand expressivism, one must first understand what it opposed. From roughly the 1880s through the mid-twentieth century, American college writing instruction was dominated by what composition scholars have retrospectively labeled Current-Traditional Rhetoric (CTR). Under this paradigm, writing pedagogy emphasized correctness, formal arrangement, and the production of polished products. Students were taught to follow prescribed organizational patterns—typically the five-paragraph essay—and were evaluated primarily on surface-level features such as grammar, punctuation, and adherence to conventional modes of discourse (narration, description, exposition, argumentation). The instructor functioned as an examiner and gatekeeper, marking errors on finished papers rather than intervening in the process of composition. As Donald Murray memorably

observed, most English teachers were “fully trained in the autopsy” of finished texts and then sent out to teach the living art of writing (Murray, 1972).

2.2 The Countercultural Moment

Expressivism did not emerge in a vacuum. The 1960s and early 1970s were a period of intense cultural upheaval in the United States. The civil rights movement, the anti-Vietnam War protests, the rise of the counterculture, and a pervasive questioning of institutional authority all created fertile ground for pedagogical reform. In English departments, a growing number of instructors began to challenge the authoritarian posture of the traditional classroom. If established institutions were suspect, then established modes of writing instruction—with their emphasis on conformity, correctness, and the suppression of individual expression—were equally open to critique. Expressivism channeled this broader cultural energy into a specific set of claims about writing, learning, and the self.

2.3 The Dartmouth Conference (1966)

A pivotal institutional event in this transformation was the Anglo-American Conference on the Teaching and Learning of English, held at Dartmouth College in August 1966. More than fifty scholars from the United States, the United Kingdom, and Canada gathered to discuss the state of English instruction. The conference has been described as producing a “Copernican shift” in the way writing was studied and taught in higher education (Harris, 1997). The British delegates, particularly James Britton and John Dixon, advanced a “growth model” of language learning that emphasized personal development, imaginative engagement, and expressive uses of language, in contrast to the American emphasis on the transmission of content and the mastery of discrete skills. The Dartmouth Seminar did not single-handedly create expressivism, but it provided intellectual legitimacy and international context for the process-oriented, student-centered approaches that expressivists would champion in the following decade. Its legacy persists in the emphasis on writing as a means of learning and personal growth that runs through the Writing Across the Curriculum movement and the National Writing Project.

3 Core Principles

Expressivism rests on a cluster of interrelated theoretical commitments, several of which stand in direct opposition to Current-Traditional assumptions.

Writing as self-discovery. The most fundamental expressivist claim is that writing is not merely a medium for communicating ideas that already exist fully formed in the writer’s mind. Rather,

meaning emerges through the act of composing itself. Writers do not know what they think until they have written it. This epistemological claim—that writing is a mode of inquiry, not merely a mode of transmission—is the philosophical core of the movement.

The authentic voice. Expressivists hold that every writer possesses a distinctive voice and that good writing instruction helps students discover and develop that voice rather than suppress it in favor of generic academic prose. Ken Macrorie coined the term “English” to describe the “phony, pretentious language of the schools”—the stilted, impersonal prose that students produce when they believe they must sound authoritative rather than authentic (Macrorie, 1970). Against English, expressivists valorize writing that sounds like a real human being speaking truthfully.

Freewriting and the organic process. Because meaning is discovered rather than planned, expressivists are skeptical of rigid outlines and formulaic structures imposed before drafting begins. They favor instead organic, exploratory approaches such as freewriting—the practice of writing continuously without stopping to edit, censor, or evaluate. Freewriting is designed to bypass the internal critic and give the writer access to material that more controlled modes of composing would suppress.

Writing as developmental. Expressivists view writing ability not as a fixed competence but as a capacity that develops over time through sustained practice, experimentation, and reflection. This developmental view implies patience with imperfect drafts, tolerance of error in early stages, and an understanding that growth in writing is nonlinear and often messy.

Rejection of product-centered evaluation. Because the process of writing is as important as—or more important than—the finished product, expressivists resist pedagogies that focus exclusively on grading final papers. They advocate instead for multiple drafts, portfolios, reflective self-assessment, and de-emphasis of grades as the primary motivational mechanism in the writing classroom.

4 Key Figures and Texts

4.1 Donald Murray

Donald Murray, a Pulitzer Prize-winning journalist who became a professor of English at the University of New Hampshire, is often credited with inaugurating the process movement in composition. His 1972 essay “Teach Writing as a Process Not Product,” delivered as a luncheon address at the New England Association of Teachers of English conference in Kennebunkport, Maine, is one of the most widely cited texts in composition studies. Murray argued that writing teachers should stop performing autopsies on finished texts and instead teach “unfinished writing,” guiding students through “the process of discovery through language.” He identified the composing

process as a continuous dialectic between opposing impulses—exploring and clarifying, collecting and combining, reading and writing—and insisted that this recursive process, not the polished final draft, should be the object of instruction (Murray, 1972). In the 1970s and 1980s, Murray’s influence was pervasive; as one commentator noted, “everyone was teaching ‘process’ probably because Donald Murray had told them to.”

4.2 Ken Macrorie

Ken Macrorie’s *Telling Writing*, first published in 1970, was one of the foundational “anti-textbooks” of the expressivist movement. Macrorie opened the book with a chapter called “The Poison Fish,” in which he introduced the concept of “Engfish”—his derisive term for the hollow, formulaic prose that students learn to produce in school. Against this institutional language, Macrorie urged students to write with honesty, specificity, and personal engagement. “The most important component to good writing,” Macrorie argued, “is telling a truth, not *the* truth.” Truthful writing, even if grammatically imperfect, was preferable to polished prose devoid of genuine thought or feeling. *Telling Writing* became a standard text in composition courses and helped establish the expressivist emphasis on authenticity, personal narrative, and the rejection of artificial academic conventions (Macrorie, 1970).

4.3 Peter Elbow

Peter Elbow is arguably the most influential and theoretically sophisticated of the expressivist writers. His *Writing Without Teachers* (1973) and *Writing with Power* (1981) together constitute the most sustained articulation of expressivist principles. Elbow’s contributions are sufficiently distinctive and complex to warrant separate treatment in Section 6 below.

5 Pedagogical Methods

Expressivist pedagogy is characterized by a set of classroom practices that follow logically from its theoretical commitments.

Freewriting. The signature technique of expressivist pedagogy, freewriting asks students to write continuously for a set period—typically ten to twenty minutes—without stopping, editing, or censoring themselves. The goal is not to produce polished prose but to generate raw material, to overcome the paralysis of the blank page, and to access thoughts and connections that more deliberate composing might suppress. Peter Elbow described freewriting as writing “without stopping, without editing, without sharing, without worrying about grammar, without thinking, without rushing” (Elbow, 1973).

Journals and personal writing. Expressivists frequently assign journals, diaries, and other forms of personal writing as regular practice. These low-stakes assignments are designed to build fluency, encourage reflection, and provide a space where students can experiment with voice and form without the pressure of formal evaluation.

Peer review workshops. The teacherless writing class, as Elbow conceived it, replaces the authority of the instructor with the collaborative feedback of peers. In workshop settings, students share drafts and respond to one another's writing, offering descriptions of their reading experience rather than prescriptive judgments. This practice redistributes authority in the classroom, positioning the writer as the primary agent and the audience as a resource rather than a judge.

Teacher as facilitator. In the expressivist classroom, the instructor functions not as an examiner who assigns grades and marks errors but as a facilitator who creates conditions for writing, responds as a reader, and offers guidance through the composing process. The teacher's role is to support, encourage, and model writerly habits rather than to enforce standards of correctness.

Multiple drafts and revision. Because writing is understood as a process of discovery, expressivists expect students to produce multiple drafts. Revision is not merely proofreading or error correction; it is a substantive rethinking of the piece, a re-seeing of its subject and purpose that may involve fundamental restructuring.

De-emphasis of grades. Many expressivists have advocated reducing or eliminating the role of grades in writing courses, arguing that the threat of evaluation inhibits risk-taking and authentic self-expression. Portfolio assessment, contract grading, and narrative evaluation have all been proposed as alternatives.

6 Elbow's Specific Contributions

Peter Elbow's work deserves extended attention because it goes beyond general expressivist principles to offer a distinctive set of concepts and techniques.

6.1 Growing and Cooking

In *Writing Without Teachers*, Elbow introduces two central metaphors for the composing process. "Growing" refers to the generative phase in which the writer produces raw material through freewriting and exploratory drafting, committing what Elbow candidly calls "the messy garbage inside one's head" to paper. "Cooking" refers to the transformative phase in which this raw material is heated, combined, and distilled. During cooking, the subconscious "bubbles up to the surface," and the writer begins to find, in Elbow's vivid phrase, "good bits wrapped in shit." Only after the material has been fully laid out and cooked can the writer begin the work of selection, summary,

and shaping. The distinction between growing and cooking is Elbow's way of insisting that generation and evaluation are distinct cognitive activities that should not be performed simultaneously (Elbow, 1973).

6.2 Center of Gravity

Elbow introduces the concept of “center of gravity” as a tool for both writers and readers. When a draft has been produced, the writer (or a peer reader) is asked to identify its center of gravity—the main point, feeling, or energy around which the piece implicitly organizes itself. This center of gravity may not correspond to the writer's stated thesis or intention; it is what the writing actually cares about, as opposed to what the writer thinks it should care about. Through iterative cycles of writing and summing-up, the center of gravity gradually “pops out,” providing the writer with a discovered focus that is more authentic and energizing than a thesis imposed in advance (Elbow, 1973).

6.3 The Believing Game and the Doubting Game

In one of his most philosophically ambitious contributions, Elbow distinguishes between two complementary modes of engaging with ideas. The “doubting game” is the mode of critical analysis: approaching a text or argument skeptically, looking for errors, contradictions, and hidden assumptions. This is what Elbow calls “the rhetoric of propositions.” The “believing game,” by contrast, asks the reader to enter sympathetically into an idea, to try it on as a hypothesis, to see more things in terms of it or through it. This is “the rhetoric of experience.” Elbow argues that Western intellectual culture overvalues the doubting game at the expense of the believing game, and that genuine understanding requires both. In the writing classroom, the believing game underwrites the practice of generous, descriptive feedback: readers tell writers what they experienced rather than what they judged to be wrong (Elbow, 1973; 1986).

7 Criticisms

Expressivism has been the subject of sustained and often sharp criticism from multiple theoretical perspectives.

7.1 Berlin's Ideological Critique

The most influential critique came from James Berlin, who in his landmark essay “Rhetoric and Ideology in the Writing Class” (1988) argued that expressivism is not the liberation from ideology

that it claims to be but is rather a vehicle for a particular ideology—liberal individualism—that it refuses to examine. Berlin classified the rhetorical approaches present in the writing classroom into three categories: cognitive rhetoric, expressionist rhetoric, and social-epistemic rhetoric. He argued that cognitive rhetoric ignores ideology while expressivism claims to transcend it, and that both are therefore incapable of subjecting their own assumptions to critique. Expressivism, Berlin contended, presupposes “the inherent goodness of the individual, a goodness distorted by excessive contact with others in groups and institutions.” This romantic individualism, Berlin argued, unwittingly reinforces the very capitalist ideology it imagines itself opposing, because it locates agency and meaning in the isolated self rather than in collective social action. Berlin advocated instead for social-epistemic rhetoric, which acknowledges its own ideological commitments and provides mechanisms for critiquing them (Berlin, 1988).

7.2 Social Constructionist Critiques

Related to Berlin’s critique but distinct from it, social constructionists such as David Bartholomae and Patricia Bizzell argued that expressivism’s emphasis on the individual writer’s authentic voice obscures the extent to which all writing is shaped by discourse communities, institutional contexts, and social power relations. Bartholomae, in his influential essay “Inventing the University” (1986), argued that student writers do not simply express a pre-existing self; they must learn to approximate the conventions and authority structures of academic discourse. From this perspective, expressivism’s injunction to “find your voice” is not merely naive but potentially harmful, because it fails to equip students with the rhetorical knowledge they need to participate in the disciplinary conversations that matter for their academic and professional lives.

7.3 Accusations of Anti-Intellectualism

Some critics have charged expressivism with anti-intellectualism, arguing that its emphasis on personal experience, emotional authenticity, and hostility to formal conventions amounts to a retreat from the rigors of academic inquiry. The de-emphasis of argument, evidence, and disciplinary knowledge in favor of personal narrative and self-expression, these critics contend, leaves students unprepared for the demands of advanced academic work. This critique has been particularly sharp in the context of first-year composition courses, where expressivist approaches have sometimes been seen as failing to introduce students to the expectations of university-level writing.

8 Legacy

Despite—or perhaps partly because of—these criticisms, expressivism has left a deep and lasting imprint on writing instruction in the United States and beyond.

Creative writing programs. The workshop model that dominates MFA programs in creative writing is, in many respects, an expressivist pedagogy: students produce drafts, share them with peers, receive descriptive feedback, and revise. The emphasis on voice, authenticity, and the development of the individual writer’s sensibility is thoroughly expressivist in origin.

The National Writing Project. The National Writing Project, which since 1974 has trained hundreds of thousands of K-12 teachers in process-oriented writing pedagogy, draws heavily on expressivist principles. Freewriting, journaling, peer response, and the teacher-as-writer model are staples of NWP professional development.

The concept of voice. Perhaps the most pervasive legacy of expressivism is the widespread use of “voice” as a criterion for evaluating writing. When teachers and editors say that a piece of writing has a “strong voice” or that a student needs to “find their voice,” they are operating within a conceptual framework that expressivism did more than any other movement to establish.

Low-stakes writing. The expressivist practice of assigning low-stakes or no-stakes writing—freewriting, journals, in-class writing exercises—has been widely adopted across composition pedagogies, including those that are otherwise hostile to expressivism. The insight that fluency develops through frequent, low-pressure practice has become pedagogical common sense.

Critical expressivism. In recent years, a number of scholars have attempted to revitalize expressivism by addressing the criticisms leveled against it. The 2014 collection *Critical Expressivism: Theory and Practice in the Composition Classroom*, edited by Tara Roeder and Roseanne Gatto, represents a sustained effort to integrate expressivist commitments to voice, personal writing, and the composing process with social constructionist attention to discourse communities, power relations, and cultural context. This “critical expressivism” seeks to create what one scholar has called “a more flexible version of each philosophy,” in which expressivist techniques serve socially aware and culturally responsive ends.

9 Conclusion

Expressivism emerged from a specific historical moment—the countercultural ferment of the 1960s and 1970s, the institutional crisis of Current-Traditional Rhetoric, and the intellectual stimulus of the Dartmouth Conference—but its influence has extended far beyond that moment. Its central insight, that writing is a mode of thinking and self-discovery rather than merely a vehicle for transmitting pre-existing ideas, has become a foundational assumption of contemporary composition stud-

ies, even among scholars who reject the expressivist label. Its characteristic practices—freewriting, peer workshops, multiple drafts, the de-emphasis of grades—have been absorbed into the mainstream of writing pedagogy. At the same time, the criticisms advanced by Berlin, Bartholomae, and others have compelled the field to think more carefully about the social and ideological dimensions of writing that expressivism, in its original formulations, tended to occlude. The ongoing project of critical expressivism suggests that the tradition retains intellectual vitality precisely because it continues to provoke productive debate about the relationship between the individual writer and the social world in which writing takes place.

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